What Pilate Walked Away From: Truth and Fallible Realism

Commentary 4

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Argument

This essay asks what truth is, beginning from the Correspondence Theory that Aristotle first stated and that most people still assume. It follows the challenges correspondence has faced, from Locke's secondary qualities, Berkeley's idealism, and Kant's things in themselves to Strawson's doubts about facts and the paradoxes of bivalence, and it examines the main alternatives: verificationism, coherence, deflationism, and pragmatism. Gathering these into two schools, it argues that objectivism fails not because there is no objective truth, but because no one can claim to know it, as the history of overturned beliefs from Kuhn to Laudan shows; relativism, meanwhile, refutes itself and, as Orwell saw, serves those who would impose truths of their own. It concludes for Fallible Realism: the assumption that one objective reality exists, joined to the admission that no human perspective can grasp it fully, so that certainty in any belief becomes the ultimate enemy.

When Jesus told Pontius Pilate that he had come "to bear witness unto the truth," Pilate answered with the question that has outlasted both of them: "What is truth?"[1] He did not wait for a reply. Philosophy has spent two thousand years supplying the answers Pilate walked away from.

The contemporary landscape of both theoretical and applicable thought is flooded with theories concerning what is, and ought to be considered, true. Truth, for the purposes of this paper, is defined within its relation to bivalence logic, meaning the idea that any given statement, p, has exactly one of two possible truth values, true or false, and never both. This binary view often pairs with the Correspondence Theory of Truth, which is the belief that

[1]John 18:37–38 (King James Version).

truth is the relationship between a statement and a corresponding fact in the world. This is often how the modern public understands truth, as a simple true-or-false assertion. This idea is one of the earliest understandings of truth, being developed by Aristotle in his *Metaphysics*:

> "To say of what is that it is not, or of what is not that it is, is false, while to say of what is that it is, and of what is not that it is not, is true."[2]

Often quoted as the foundations of the Correspondence Theory, Aristotle argues further in his works that truth is determined by reality, saying the following in another passage of the *Metaphysics*:

> "It is not because we think truly that you are white, that you are white, but because you are white we who say this have the truth."[3]

Essentially, as evidenced from the above excerpts, Correspondence Theory asserts that truth is a relation between what we say and what is, and quite intuitively so. It is, for all intents and purposes, both incredibly difficult and historically unsuccessful to disagree with the above theory on truth. Take the example: as one man may say to another, "This table is surely brown, how could you say otherwise?" And yet, there have been several attempts to hold the table is in fact probably not brown.

The first came from John Locke, who divided the qualities of objects into primary qualities and secondary qualities. In the former category he placed such characteristics as size, shape, and motion, which he argued exist in the object itself. This is often misunderstood as a claim to know the object in and of itself, but Locke does not mean it so. He is instead holding that without onlookers, the object's size is objective. Whether you are looking at the table or not, the table is size A.[4] Often people will conflate this with the separate question of whether objects exist independently of minds at all, which is merited and often discussed, but is not Locke's argument. It runs parallel to his point, but they are not the same issue. Locke holds the idea that primary qualities are in the objects themselves; his issue is not with the physicality of the existence of these objects, which is an objection Berkeley will later raise, but rather with the issue that the objects' "real essences" cannot be asserted with certainty. Our ideas of primary qualities are "resemblances" of the qualities themselves, while what lies beneath them, the real essence, stays hidden.[5] In the latter category secondary qualities are placed, such as color, taste, and sound. These are said, by Locke, to exist in the

[2]Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, trans. W. D. Ross (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1908), bk. IV, ch. 7, 1011b26–27.

[3]Aristotle, *Metaphysics*, bk. IX, ch. 10, 1051b6–9.

[4]John Locke, *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1690), bk. II, ch. 8, §§9–10.

[5]Locke, *Essay*, II.8.15, on resemblances; III.3.15–18 and III.6.9, on real essences.

eye of the viewer, but it must be noted that Locke does not see these as entirely subjective. Locke instead supports the idea of the inherent "power" of these secondary qualities, while acknowledging that without a taster, smeller, or viewer the power will remain unrecognized. For example, while a table's size may be absolute, a table's sound or color may not be so. Some people may see it as brown, others a certain shade of red, etc. Without a viewer, the color is never realized. Perhaps the most understandable example comes in the form of taste or smell of a dish in a restaurant. A plate of fish is brought to you, the plate of food has certain dimensions, mass, (hopefully not motion in this case), but without the patron there to taste the dish, the dish's taste is never realized. Taste only exists if the dish is being tasted, whereas size or mass of the dish exists whether a patron is eating it or if it is simply waiting in the kitchen to be run out to the table who ordered it. Locke puts it as such, calling secondary qualities those which

> "[I]n truth are nothing in the objects themselves but powers to produce various sensations in us by their primary qualities."[6]

Locke's view is essentially thus: going back to the table analogy, the table has a shape whether or not anyone looks at it; its brownness exists as a power only realized in the meeting of the table and an eye of a particular viewer. This is best summed up with an example Locke gives himself, which tells against a total relativism of reality. Paraphrased from Locke, the idea is essentially that an individual puts one hand in hot water and the other in cold, then plunges both into lukewarm water.[7] The same water feels cold to one hand and warm to the other. Water can't be both, so the warmth must therefore be in the individual, which supports the idea that reality may seem relative without physically being so.

George Berkeley went further than Locke, arguing that the primary qualities fare no better than the secondary, so that for any physical object, its *esse* is *percipi*: to be is to be perceived.[8] Berkeley's argument is mostly directed against Locke, and one of Berkeley's objections serves to expose a possible leap in Locke's logical framework, as Berkeley asks the reader to imagine a shape in their mind. Whether they imagine a square, rectangle, triangle, or dodecahedron, the imaginer will have given a color to the shape; whether it was a white square or a yellow triangle doesn't matter. What is of consequence is that Locke's distinction between primary qualities and secondary qualities seems to collapse, or at least that it raises concerns over the rigor of the distinction Locke drew.[9]

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[6]Locke, *Essay*, II.8.10.

[7]Locke, *Essay*, II.8.21.

[8]George Berkeley, *A Treatise Concerning the Principles of Human Knowledge* (1710), pt. I, §3.

[9]Berkeley, *Principles*, pt. I, §10.

Immanuel Kant, the philosopher of Königsberg, took a stand between Locke and Berkeley. Kant argued, to use the table example, that there is a table in itself, but we know only the table as it appears to us, shaped by the structure of our own perception, and never the thing in itself.[10] Superficially, this reminds some of Plato's realm of the forms, but in fact they are quite divergent in many places, and in three most notably. Plato argued that the realm of the forms, of true reality, is attainable and is the highest form of knowledge;[11] Kant does not think as such, instead arguing that this higher knowledge is unknowable, even by reason. Plato also argued that the imperfections in objects in this world are within those objects, meaning physical objects are imperfect replicas of forms and the imperfection is within the object of this world. Kant instead held that space, time, and cause and effect are the systems our minds impose on experiences, and therefore the table isn't a degraded copy of anything. Instead, it is how any mind built like ours must receive whatever is there. Finally, for Plato the world of appearance is a lesser reality, close to illusion, while for Kant it is fully real for us, the proper object of science; what he denies is only that it is the thing in itself.

Correspondence theory found its most rigorous modern form in the early twentieth century. Bertrand Russell held that a belief is true when there is a fact that corresponds to it, and false when there is not,[12] and Ludwig Wittgenstein built a whole picture of language on Russell's idea, opening his *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus* (1921) with the claim that "the world is the totality of facts, not of things."[13] A sentence, Wittgenstein argued, is a picture of a possible fact, saying, "The picture agrees with reality or not; it is right or wrong, true or false."[14] The difficulty in this framework lies in saying what a fact truly is, and on that subject there are essentially two main schools of thought, one in support of correspondence, and one against. J. L. Austin's view defended correspondence as a matter of conventions linking words to situations, a more modest version of the theory.[15] In favor of the opposing view, P. F. Strawson replied that facts are not things in the world at all, but simply what a certain statement (when true) actually states.[16] The issue is not that correspondence theory

[10]Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason* (1781; 2nd ed. 1787), trans. Paul Guyer and Allen W. Wood (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), Bxvi–xviii and A26/B42.

[11]Plato, *Republic*, bks. VI–VII, 507b–518b.

[12]Bertrand Russell, *The Problems of Philosophy* (London: Williams and Norgate, 1912), ch. 12.

[13]Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, trans. C. K. Ogden (London: Kegan Paul, 1922), 1.1.

[14]Wittgenstein, *Tractatus*, 2.21.

[15]J. L. Austin, "Truth," *Proceedings of the Aristotelian Society*, supp. vol. 24 (1950): 111–128.

[16]P. F. Strawson, "Truth," *Proceedings of the Aristotelian Society*, supp. vol. 24 (1950): 129–156.

is demonstrably false, simply that Strawson's objection serves to raise a larger question as to the validity of this theory, as it suggests that a "fact" may be nothing over and above the true statement itself, in which case saying that a statement corresponds to a fact explains nothing. Another dent in the armor of this theory is that it is usually paired with bivalence logic, or the idea that a statement is either true or false, and while some thinkers have attempted to patch this gap by adding a third value, "possible,"[17] this reliance on bivalence logic leads down a road of a great many paradoxical claims, none perhaps more famous than "This sentence is false."[18] Clearly, while pragmatic and popular, correspondence faces objections and seemingly paradoxical logical underpinnings that make it logical to investigate other theories of truth, while regarding correspondence as oversimplified rather than demonstrably false.

A popular theory to contest mainstream claims of truth is the Verification Theory, strictly a theory of meaning rather than of truth, which essentially describes a statement as meaningful only if it can be empirically proved true or false; on this view, most of the statements we take for granted as true in fact have no underlying truth value (neither true nor false), as Ayer puts it in the excerpt below from his work, *Language, Truth and Logic*:

> "We say that a sentence is factually significant to any given person, if, and only if, he knows how to verify the proposition which it purports to express—that is, if he knows what observations would lead him, under certain conditions, to accept the proposition as being true, or reject it as being false."[19]

This theory, seemingly logical and proposition driven, led Ayer to reject many metaphysical claims made by theologians, metaphysicians, and moral philosophers alike. Yet, it has largely fallen out of favor in the modern landscape, due to a paradox present within Ayer's verification principle. Under his own framework, Ayer deems statements that cannot be verified "devoid of literal significance," and the work of those who make them "the production of nonsense."[20] Ironically, his Verification Principle lacks any observations that would lead him to accept the proposition as being true, or reject it as being false, rendering it self-refuting and, under Ayer's own logical system, untenable. Ayer saw this objection and answered it. In the introduction to the second edition of 1946, he wrote that he wished the principle of verification to be viewed as a definition: a proposal about how the word "meaningful" should be used, which

[17] Jan Łukasiewicz, "On Three-Valued Logic" (1920), in *Selected Works*, ed. L. Borkowski (Amsterdam: North-Holland, 1970).

[18] On the liar paradox, and the view that some statements are both true and false, see Graham Priest, *In Contradiction* (Dordrecht: Martinus Nijhoff, 1987).

[19] A. J. Ayer, *Language, Truth and Logic* (London: Victor Gollancz, 1936), ch. 1.

[20] Ayer, *Language, Truth and Logic*, ch. 1.

need not pass its own test.[21] Ayer himself later gave up the defense. Asked in 1978 what the main defect of the logical positivist movement had been, he answered: "Well I suppose the most important of the defects was that nearly all of it was false."[22]

While even one of the fathers of the movement eventually abandoned it as false, the idea Ayer staked this work on is not as easily disregarded. Perhaps Ayer's conclusion that any statement that cannot be verified is nonsensical was extreme and even paradoxical, but the idea that we should accept as true only what can be empirically shown is not as much of an overclaiming idea. David Hume, the famous empiricist, was of this school of thought, ending his *Enquiry* by asking of any book that contained neither reasoning about number nor reasoning about matters of fact: "Commit it then to the flames: for it can contain nothing but sophistry and illusion."[23] And it is perhaps here where a distinction should be drawn. Ayer held that any unverifiable claim is nonsense, any claim about God, theology, etc. that could not be verified; but perhaps Ayer was arguing too sweepingly in asserting that these statements are non-propositional and are instead certainly propositional, but not truthful. The most tenable strand of this theory of truth is when a line is drawn between verifiable statements and non-verifiable statements. On this view, verifiable statements, once verified, are true, while non-verifiable statements, instead of being nonsense, are simply beliefs whose truth cannot be checked. This paper does not accept the first half of that line, for reasons outlined directly below. The second half is close to the line Karl Popper would later draw, and to which this commentary will return later:[24] a claim that cannot be tested is not meaningless, only currently outside the reach of evidence.

For instance, take the claim "unicorns are real." It seems to be unverifiable, but it is not: find a unicorn, and the claim is verified. What can never be done is to prove it false, since no search can cover every forest on earth. A truly unverifiable claim is one that no observation could settle either way. Carl Sagan offered one: a dragon living in his garage, which is invisible, floats so it leaves no footprints, and gives off no heat, so that every test proposed, it explains away.[25] Under Ayer's framework, the dragon is nonsense; under the more tenable verificationist framework, it is a belief disguised as a claim. The issue here is

[21] A. J. Ayer, *Language, Truth and Logic*, 2nd ed. (London: Victor Gollancz, 1946), introduction.

[22] A. J. Ayer, interviewed by Bryan Magee in *Men of Ideas* (BBC Television, 1978); published in Bryan Magee, *Men of Ideas* (London: BBC, 1978).

[23] David Hume, *An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding* (1748), sec. XII, pt. 3.

[24] Karl Popper, *The Logic of Scientific Discovery* (London: Hutchinson, 1959; first published as *Logik der Forschung*, 1934), ch. 1.

[25] Carl Sagan, *The Demon-Haunted World: Science as a Candle in the Dark* (New York: Random House, 1995), ch. 10.

that this belief is reliant on a claim not supported by evidence.

Yet even a verified claim is not certainly true, and it was Hume who showed why. No number of past observations proves what the next one will be:

> "That the sun will not rise to-morrow is no less intelligible a proposition, and implies no more contradiction, than the affirmation, that it will rise."[26]

For centuries, every swan any European had seen was white, and "all swans are white" was as well verified as a claim can be, until Dutch sailors found black swans in Australia in 1697.[27] Verification can support a claim, but it can never make it certain. Hume drew the lesson rather eloquently himself: "A wise man, therefore, proportions his belief to the evidence."[28]

There are several other theories on truth as well.

The most consequential is perhaps the Coherence Theory of Truth, which does not hold that a belief is true because it matches a fact, but instead a belief is true if it fits within a consistent system of other beliefs; it is, essentially, a theory of truth that declares truthful what is expected within an existing framework. One of its main tenets is the idea we can never step outside our beliefs to compare them with the world: every check we run on a belief is made against other beliefs. Otto Neurath gave the view its best-known image:

> "We are like sailors who must rebuild their ship on the open sea, never able to dismantle it in dry-dock and to reconstruct it there out of the best materials."[29]

It was F. H. Bradley and Brand Blanshard, however, who developed it into a full theory.[30] Blanshard perhaps rather boldly argued in *The Nature of Thought* that coherence is not merely the test of truth but the very nature of truth itself.[31] The standard objection came from Bertrand Russell, who pointed out in *The Problems of Philosophy* that more than one system can be perfectly consistent: "a novelist might invent a past for the world that would perfectly fit on to what we know, and yet be quite different from the real past."[32]

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[26]Hume, *Enquiry*, sec. IV, pt. 1.

[27]The black swans were recorded by the Dutch expedition of Willem de Vlamingh on the Swan River in western Australia. The swan became the standard illustration of Hume's problem later, through John Stuart Mill and Karl Popper; it is not Hume's own example.

[28]Hume, *Enquiry*, sec. X, pt. 1.

[29]Otto Neurath, "Protocol Sentences" (1932–33), trans. George Schick, in *Logical Positivism*, ed. A. J. Ayer (Glencoe, IL: Free Press, 1959), 201.

[30]F. H. Bradley, *Essays on Truth and Reality* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1914).

[31]Brand Blanshard, *The Nature of Thought* (London: George Allen and Unwin, 1939).

[32]Russell, *The Problems of Philosophy*, ch. 12.

This is one of the most well known objections, and is one of the strongest, especially when outlined using historical examples. In the Antebellum southern United States a plantation owner could have very tenably, under this framework, claimed the belief that African slaves were inherently inferior to whites, as the existing system of belief and the existing system of practice seemed to justify it. African slaves were less literate (largely because the law forbade teaching them to read)[33], less educated, consigned to slavery in large swaths, and were used to directly serve the white upper class. Obviously that was the system of the time, and many slavers and southerners made this very argument, when in fact the corrupted system of slavery existed to produce the very "truth" they claimed must follow from the existing system of belief. It is important to note, in the case of this example, that this objection is an internal one, and this theory depends on beliefs not practicality. Some counterarguments to this objection are that the physical system supported the claim of inferiority but the underlying system of belief did not, and to that the most common response is that physical systems often reflect underlying beliefs, true or not. Whatever the merit of such replies, the underlying belief of white southerners was that inferiority was true within the belief system that African slaves ought to serve whites, that they are not capable of autonomy, etc. The overarching idea is that a coherent system of belief can be built on an untrue foundation, and then serve to support and defend the very system that engineered it.

The other two viewpoints concerning truth are the Deflationary Theory of Truth and the Pragmatic Theory of Truth. The former says that truth is not a property that supports propositions but a linguistic tool for affirming statements. Frank Ramsey put it most simply when he said,

> " 'It is true that Caesar was murdered' means no more than that Caesar was murdered."[34]

Everything there is to say about the truth of a sentence is said by the sentence itself. Essentially, truth is simply a tool used to answer in the affirmative to statements on varying subjects. Paul Horwich's minimalism, the most developed modern version of this theory, holds that the whole meaning of "true" is given by such instances as evidenced by Caesar above. Horwich's argument, set out in his book *Truth* (1990) and defended in "A Defense of Minimalism" (2001), is twofold.[35] He argues for what some more formal thinkers call the

[33]Southern states passed anti-literacy laws forbidding the teaching of enslaved people to read and write, beginning with South Carolina's Negro Act of 1740 and extended across much of the South after 1830.

[34]F. P. Ramsey, "Facts and Propositions," *Proceedings of the Aristotelian Society*, supp. vol. 7 (1927): 153–170.

[35]Paul Horwich, *Truth* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1990; 2nd ed., Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1998);

equivalence schema, which is more simplistic than it may seem, as it simply argues that: The proposition that p is true if and only if p. Exemplified as such, under this framework, "snow is white" is true if and only if snow is white. The second part of his argument concerned a more semantical defense of the use of the word "true." As one might notice, under Horwich's framework, true seems quite trivial but Horwich does not think it so, arguing instead in favor of the use of the word as a convenient tool of language, not as purporting any sense of metaphysical meaning. This appears as a tenable argument, and a common one at that, even mentioned in Ogden and Richards' *The Meaning of Meaning*, particularly in chapter nine,[36] although they do warn about using convenience as a scapegoat for peopling the world with fictitious entities. Nevertheless, Horwich's argument has been challenged many times, and in two main ways. Firstly, it was challenged as refusing to provide any sense of general truth, as minimalism in Horwich's tradition typically applied truth values on an individual basis. Since the theory is only an endless list of instances, it cannot prove general claims about truth, such as that every statement of the form "if p, then p" is true, even though each instance can be proved one at a time.[37] Horwich attempts to remedy this with a further rule of inference that licenses the general claim once every instance is provable; yet, the degree to which this response is successful is heavily situational and heavily contested. The more damning objection is that in the famed liar paradox, Horwich's theory breaks down completely. If every instance of the schema is an axiom, then the schema itself breaks down inside this paradox, which led Horwich to exclude the paradoxical instances from his schema, without a principled way of saying which those are, so that the theory is propped up by an exception made to keep it from failing. This makes deflationary theory more of an assertion about how we use truth, and what individuals connote by truth, but lacking in any general defensible claims concerning more metaphysical truth.

Pragmatism's founder, Charles Sanders Peirce, defined truth as "the opinion which is fated to be ultimately agreed to by all who investigate,"[38] while William James made it more practical still:

> "The truth of an idea is not a stagnant property inherent in it. Truth happens to an idea. It becomes true, is made true by events."[39]

"A Defense of Minimalism," *Synthese* 126 (2001): 149–165.

[36]C. K. Ogden and I. A. Richards, *The Meaning of Meaning* (London: Kegan Paul, Trench, Trubner, 1923), ch. 9.

[37]Anil Gupta, "Minimalism," *Philosophical Perspectives* 7 (1993): 359–369.

[38]Charles Sanders Peirce, "How to Make Our Ideas Clear," *Popular Science Monthly* 12 (1878): 286–302.

[39]William James, *Pragmatism: A New Name for Some Old Ways of Thinking* (New York:

Bertrand Russell's reply to James was swift, as one may imagine, and rather consequential. Russell argued that if a belief is true whenever it works, then "Santa Claus exists" is true for any child whom the belief makes happy, which no one truthfully believes.[40] Many thinkers separate deflationary theory of truth and pragmatism, but they run in tandem as they fail to support generalized truth principles, but do provide individuals with insight into how truth is applied in a non-metaphysical context and how truth functions in our language in daily life, making them far from useless or inconsequential and quite the opposite in fields of semantics and philosophy of language.

Generalized somewhat, these theories suggest two schools of thought: objective truth (Correspondence, Peirce's Pragmatism, and many religious traditions) and relative truth (James's Pragmatism, Social Construction Theory, Postmodernism, and Interpretational truth). Coherence and Deflationism sit apart from both: Coherence makes truth a matter of fit among beliefs rather than of objectivity, and Deflationism denies there is any property of truth to be objective or relative about. Every theory has its nuances, many of which were discussed above, but looking at these ideas from a broader perspective often allows thinkers to identify weaknesses, or possible improvements that one may not see when he or she is "in the weeds" of metaphysical analysis.

Objective truth gives society a moral framework to claim there is right and wrong action based on unchanging truths. However, the objection often raised against this theory is that if truth is objective, how do we know we've fully and correctly understood it? History is littered with purported truths such as Social Darwinism, racial hierarchies, and the earth at the center of the universe, that were later overturned as perhaps less demonstrably supportable positions to hold. Thomas Kuhn gave this history objection its most influential theory. In *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, he argued that science does not advance by steadily adding truths, but by revolutions in which one framework, or paradigm, replaces another: Ptolemy's earth-centered heavens give way to Copernicus's sun-centered ones, Newton's absolute space to Einstein's relativity. Each paradigm defines what counts as a problem and what counts as an answer, so that, in Kuhn's words, "though the world does not change with a change of paradigm, the scientist afterward works in a different world."[41] Larry Laudan pressed the historical point further. In "A Confutation of Convergent Realism," he listed theories that were once successful and are now held to be false: the crystalline spheres

Longmans, Green, 1907), lecture VI.

[40]Bertrand Russell, "William James's Conception of Truth" (1908), in *Philosophical Essays* (London: Longmans, Green, 1910).

[41]Thomas S. Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1962), ch. 10.

of ancient astronomy, the humoral theory of medicine, phlogiston, the luminiferous ether. If most successful theories of the past turned out false, he argued, we should expect the same of our own; this has come to be called the pessimistic meta-induction.[42] The realist's reply is Hilary Putnam's: realism "is the only philosophy that doesn't make the success of science a miracle."[43] If our theories were not at least approximately true, it would be a mystery that bridges stand and medicines cure. The objectivist here would have to assert that humanity somehow has knowledge of objective truth, which is difficult to claim considering the limitations of our knowledge in most other subjects as evidenced by Laudan's listing of formerly accepted, now discarded theories. Distinct cultures are also of some use here. Unique cultures have historically endorsed distinct truths, suggesting that our own accepted truths may also be quite fallible when viewed from others' eyes. Herodotus tells the oldest version of the point. The Persian king Darius asked a group of Greeks, who burned their dead, what price would persuade them to eat their fathers' bodies; they answered that no price would. He then asked a tribe of Callatians, who ate their dead, what price would persuade them to burn their fathers; they cried out at the horror of it. Herodotus concluded with the poet Pindar that "custom is king of all."[44] Ironically, claimed objective knowledge falls prey to sheer relativism, as what is called objective is assumed from the majority, and as the majority shifts, these "objective truths" shift, yet objective truths do not shift, lest they cease to be objective. The objection, then, is not to the existence of objective truth, but to our claim to know it. To disprove objective truth, one would have to claim knowledge of one objective truth: that there is none. The issue then transcends objective versus relative truth and shifts to abilities to comprehend, interpret, and prove truths. The earth went round the sun the whole time the majority believed otherwise; human belief is inconsequential to the truths that the survival of the universe, earth, and humanity rely on. Objective knowledge, therefore, becomes quite tenuous when leveled against these objections, and the assumptions one must make to underpin it.

On the other hand, the oldest statement of relativism belongs to Protagoras, the Greek sophist, whose claim survives through Plato: "Man is the measure of all things: of the things which are, that they are, and of the things which are not, that they are not."[45] What is true, on this view, is what seems true to whoever judges. Plato answered him in the *Theaetetus* with

[42]Larry Laudan, "A Confutation of Convergent Realism," *Philosophy of Science* 48, no. 1 (1981): 19–49.

[43]Hilary Putnam, *Mathematics, Matter and Method*, Philosophical Papers, vol. 1 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1975), 73.

[44]Herodotus, *Histories*, bk. III, ch. 38.

[45]Plato, *Theaetetus*, 152a.

an argument that has outlived Protagoras himself: since Protagoras grants that every opinion is true, he must grant that the opinion of those who think Protagoras is wrong is also true, and so his own doctrine undermines itself.[46] Relativism returned in modern form with Nietzsche, who called truths "illusions which we have forgotten are illusions,"[47] and with Richard Rorty, who argued that "truth cannot be out there—cannot exist independently of the human mind—because sentences cannot so exist."[48] Jean-François Lyotard gave postmodernism its slogan in 1979, defining it as "incredulity toward metanarratives"[49]: suspicion of any single story, scientific, religious, or political, that claims to explain everything. Relative truth is then almost equally difficult to argue, while offering us a quite tenebrous outlook if accepted as mainstream value (note that relativism cannot coherently be held as a universal value, for to hold that all truth is relative for everyone is already to state one truth that is not relative; this grounds a more rigorous paradox discussed below). Disregarding the ominous fortunes this theory could bring society, it is as difficult to defend as objectivity, simply because relativism holds, as its name suggests, that truth is completely relative. While many thinkers concede that an individual's perception of the truth is certainly relative, it does not mean all truth is relative. As cliché as it is, take the classic "car crash on the corner" thought experiment. If four people are standing on four different sides of an intersection, and witness a car crash, all of them will likely describe it in different, non-identical ways; however, there was only one car crash, one objective car crash. Similarly, two people may look at a wood table, and one argues it's dark brown, and the other reddish-brown. There are two "realities" for the individual but only one table, and only one truth, and perhaps that truth mirrors neither of the realities purported by the bystanders, perhaps the table is in fact camel, not reddish brown or dark brown. Locke would object that color is the one place where the bystanders may both be right, since color exists only in the meeting of table and eye. Grant him that, and the point survives in his primary qualities: the bystanders may disagree about whether the table is six feet long or five, but it has one length, and a tape measure will settle the matter whatever either of them sees. The paradox mentioned in the note above goes further: if all truth is relative, then one absolute meta-truth exists (that all truth is relative). If not, then truth is not relative and Relativism fails. Relativism also

[46]Plato, *Theaetetus*, 171a–c.

[47]Friedrich Nietzsche, "On Truth and Lies in a Nonmoral Sense" (1873).

[48]Richard Rorty, *Contingency, Irony, and Solidarity* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1989), 5.

[49]Jean-François Lyotard, *The Postmodern Condition: A Report on Knowledge* (1979), trans. Geoff Bennington and Brian Massumi (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1984), xxiv.

tends to decay into a frail moral standard, which upon facing a difficult decision, may permit subjective self-serving interpretations of ethical principles, which can eventually give way to an emotivist framework of thinking, the very view Ayer himself held, that moral judgments are "pure expressions of feeling and as such do not come under the category of truth and falsehood."[50]

The danger is not only private. In *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, Orwell's Winston Smith writes in his diary that "freedom is the freedom to say that two plus two make four. If that is granted, all else follows."[51] The Party's interrogator, O'Brien, answers by torturing him until he sees five fingers where there are four, because for the Party "reality exists in the human mind, and nowhere else."[52] Harry Frankfurt later argued, in *On Bullshit* (2005), that the liar at least respects the truth enough to hide it, while the bullshitter is indifferent to it altogether, and that indifference is the greater threat.[53] It is notable that here, relativism does not altogether guarantee descent into the hell that is Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, but rather relativism is often employed by those who seek to advance their own meta-narrative under the guise of relative truth frameworks. This does not make relativism wrong, but introduces a paradox, the idea, as mentioned before, that relativism relies on one objective truth, that truth is itself not objective, and anyone claiming to know all truth is relative is an objectivist supporting their own objective beliefs masked by seemingly reasonable relativism.

This tends towards one of the final theories of truth discussed, and the one this commentary holds most tenable in the fog that is the debate on metaphysical truth.

This is fallible realism, or the assertion, held as an assumption rather than as knowledge, that there is one objective reality, yet we are incapable of perfect comprehension of that objective reality. The idea has a long lineage. Plato's prisoners in the cave mistake shadows on a wall for the real objects behind them,[54] and Kant, as above, held that we know things only as they appear to us. Peirce, the pragmatist, gave the position its modern name, fallibilism:

> "[W]e cannot in any way reach perfect certitude nor exactitude. We never can be absolutely sure of anything."[55]

Karl Popper joined that doubt to realism. Against the verificationists, he argued that

[50] Ayer, *Language, Truth and Logic*, ch. 6.

[51] George Orwell, *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (London: Secker and Warburg, 1949), pt. I, ch. 7.

[52] Orwell, *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, pt. III, ch. 2.

[53] Harry G. Frankfurt, *On Bullshit* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2005), first published in *Raritan* 6, no. 2 (1986).

[54] Plato, *Republic*, bk. VII, 514a–517a.

[55] Charles Sanders Peirce, *Collected Papers*, ed. Charles Hartshorne and Paul Weiss (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1931–35), 1.147.

no theory can ever be verified, only tested and possibly falsified, so that our best science is always the theory that has survived the hardest tests so far, never one proved true.[56] In *Conjectures and Refutations* he compared objective truth, understood as correspondence to the facts, to a mountain peak "permanently, or almost permanently, wrapped in clouds": the climber may never be sure he has reached it, but the peak is there, and it is what he is climbing toward.[57]

Fallibilism also has a practical edge. Peirce drew from it one rule that he thought deserved to be inscribed on every wall of the city of philosophy: "Do not block the way of inquiry."[58] John Stuart Mill made the same point the basis of free speech in *On Liberty* (1859): since we can never be certain an opinion is false, "all silencing of discussion is an assumption of infallibility."[59]

The table then, to reuse an analogy from above, may very well be some shade of brown, but the objective truth is masked by a fog of human ineptness. We may, in practice, possess enough knowledge to assume truth is in fact objective, as Aristotle would have us believe, but in reality, it is far more likely we are simply using pattern recognition and intuition to assume objectivity, when in reality, there are often many nuances that we consider negligible, or fail to consider at all. The position faces one objection that must be answered, and it was first put to Kant. If we can never know reality as it is in itself, how do we know there is a reality in itself at all? Friedrich Heinrich Jacobi complained in 1787 that without the thing in itself he could not enter Kant's system, and with it he could not remain inside it.[60] The fallibilist seems to claim knowledge of exactly one objective fact, that there is an objective world, while denying that we can know objective facts. This is not a new claim Jacobi makes. The idea long supported by fallible realists, falsificationists, and relativists is the famed idea that the only thing we know for certain is that we know nothing. A relativist may agree; a true fallible realist would be the first to admit that we know not even that, nor do we know there is an objective reality, nor that we aren't all living in the matrix. Fallible realism is not a theory supporting a claim on truth, it is a theory supporting that there is truth that appears objective to us, truth that may appear relative, truth that may not appear at all, and instead of holding objectivity as the answer or relativism as the answer, fallible realism

[56]Popper, *The Logic of Scientific Discovery*, ch. 1 and ch. 10.

[57]Karl Popper, *Conjectures and Refutations: The Growth of Scientific Knowledge* (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1963), ch. 10.

[58]Peirce, *Collected Papers*, 1.135.

[59]John Stuart Mill, *On Liberty* (London: John W. Parker and Son, 1859), ch. 2.

[60]Friedrich Heinrich Jacobi, *David Hume on Faith, or Idealism and Realism* (1787), supplement, "On Transcendental Idealism."

simply holds certainty in any belief as the ultimate enemy. In the eyes of a fallible realist, it is certainly possible all truth is in fact objective, or perhaps some truth is objective, some is not, the underlying argument of the fallible realist is that from our human perspective skepticism concerning absolute truth and the acknowledgment that what appears relative is likely an incomplete interpretation, formed from incomplete information through a flawed human perspective, together form the most logical approach to questions both beyond our species and ones foundational to our thriving.

Therefore, the most defensible position concerning truth in general is Fallible Realism. It assumes an objective reality but acknowledges that humans can never fully understand it. While difficult to disprove, it also prevents anyone from claiming complete certainty about the truth. Fallible Realism emphasizes the existence of an objective reality while acknowledging human fallibility, making it the most rational and historically defensible approach. Socrates, told by the oracle that no one was wiser than he, concluded that his wisdom consisted only in this: that he did not think he knew what he did not know.[61] If truth is real but never wholly within our grasp, the same question must be put to right and wrong, which the next commentary takes up.

[61]Plato, *Apology*, 21a–23b.